

What else to watch: *Bunny Lake Is Missing* (1965) ■ *Wake in Fright* (1971) ■ *Walkabout* (1971, p.337) ■ *The Year of Living Dangerously* (1982) ■ *The Blair Witch Project* (1999) ■ *The Virgin Suicides* (1999) ■ *The Way Back* (2010) ■ *The Babadook* (2014)



Irma, Marion, and Miranda share an eerily idyllic moment just before they set off to climb Hanging Rock. Irma will be found later with her corset missing. The other two, along with Miss McGraw, disappear without trace.

asking the viewer to respect the mystery for what it is. A kind of supernatural event seems to have occurred. It has no context and is therefore frightening. Weir builds his drama on this menacing atmosphere, which hums with the stifling heat of the Australian summer. He shoots Hanging Rock as though it were the surface of a hostile alien world, which is what it must have felt like to the characters. The movie is set in

1900, when European settlers were still strangers in an ancient land they did not fully understand.

Possible hint

There is a hint that sexuality is at the heart of the vanishing. When one of the girls “returns,” unable to put her experience into words, why is her corset missing? Is it significant that the vanishing occurs on Valentine’s Day? Or that the rock itself sits on a dormant volcano, a potential symbol of repressed desire? It’s impossible to know. Any answers to the riddle evaporate in the dry haze of the bush. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, it is the mystery that endures, and not the explanation. ■

“We shall only be gone a little while.”

Miranda / Picnic at Hanging Rock



Peter Weir
Director

Born in Sydney in 1944, Weir started his career making documentaries with Australia’s Commonwealth Film Unit. Associated with the movement dubbed the “Australian New Wave,” which included performers and filmmakers who found international acclaim in the 1970s and 80s, he went on to make movies that focused on communities under strain, his atmospherics mirroring the tumultuous forces affecting the characters’ lives. After the success of his World War I drama *Gallipoli*, Weir’s films have often been star vehicles that put a man into a closed society and watched him struggle to connect, such as Harrison Ford’s John Book in *Witness* (1985), set within an Amish community.

Key movies

1975 *Picnic at Hanging Rock*
1981 *Gallipoli*
1989 *Dead Poets Society*
1998 *The Truman Show*